The Technical Companion to Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back

Every economic, psychological, and design element taken out of the novel, stated plainly, and mapped to where it appears in the story

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Companion to: Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back: A novel of Orun (Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot; some scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot)

> **What this is.** The novel is fiction, and it carries no equations, citations, or meters. This companion holds all of that apparatus instead. Each element is tagged with one of three layers, as in Coherence Under Decay: **[Design]**, a rule of the invented world or of an app built on it; **[Empirical]**, a claim that can be checked against research, graded as supported, plausible, or speculative; or **[Values]**, Ryan Espinosa's convictions, which are not tested by experiment and are not diminished by being labelled. Nothing here is medical advice. In the United States, call or text **988** if you are in crisis.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

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0. How to read the mapping

Chapter numbers refer to the novel's twenty chapters. "Before" means the opening section, Before the story: Orun. A full element-to-chapter table is in Section 12.

Part	Chapters
Before the story	The basin; Five words they keep; How they live
Part One: The Morning She Tried to Buy	I–V
Part Two: In Her Name	VI–X
Part Three: The Wet Year	XI–XVI
Part Four: The Day of Enough	XVII–XX

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1. Selu: a fading currency with a floor at zero

1.1 The rules [Design]

1. **Selu fades when idle (demurrage).** A token held without moving loses value continuously. The simplest form, carried over from Coherence Under Decay (CUD), is exponential: $V(t) = V_0 \cdot e^{(-\lambda \cdot t_idle)}$, with half-life $t_{1/2} = \ln 2 / \lambda$. λ is a design parameter, not a measured constant.

2. **There is a floor at zero.** `V(t) ≥ 0` always. A balance can fade to nothing but never past nothing. There are no negative balances, no loans, no interest, and no debts. CUD writes this as the zero-debt ledger (balances ≥ 0) and uses the symbol d for debt, with d = 0 always.
3. **The morning gift is fixed and deterministic.** Every name on the dawn roll receives the same measure, every day. There is no lottery, no draw, no near-miss, no bonus for watching the table, and no escalation. Eligibility is "away from the stalls yesterday, and did not rush them on return": fields, a sickbed, the upper path, or ordinary rest at home. This follows the CUD fix: credit patience as time away from the marketplace (in an app, time off-app), not as time spent staring at the reward.
4. **Rest still fades a little.** In luoma, the safe place, selu keeps a small residual decay, `λ_s > 0`, so rest cannot become a hoarding shelter. This is the CUD "no perfect isolation" rule.
5. **Thanks, not wages.** Selu moves as thanks to makers, as permission to pass on a copy after a true mark, and as the copy-gift that funds rivel. Reading is free. Help to a stranger creates no obligation (Chapter XI).
6. **Roles rotate.** Every role "with a lamp in it" (the dawn counters, the copy-table, the keeper of the open rack) passes on at the Day of Enough, so that no one comes to think they own the lamp, or are the lamp (Chapters XII, XIX).
7. **Newcomers receive six first gifts** before anyone asks them to produce: welcome, belonging, rest, a true word, a kindness, and something they have not seen before (Before; Tulen in Chapter II; Bram in Chapter XI).

1.2 Evidence and precedent [Empirical]

- **Demurrage has real precedent, and it is thin.** Silvio Gesell proposed money that loses value over time ("Freigeld," later "stamp scrip") in Die natürliche Wirtschaftsordnung durch Freiland und Freigeld (1916). Irving Fisher discussed it in Stamp Scrip (1933). The Austrian town of Wörgl ran a stamp-scrip experiment in 1932–33 that historical accounts describe as raising local circulation before the national bank halted it. The exact Wörgl figures were not verified for this companion and are deliberately left out. **Grade: plausible as a design with historical precedent; not supported as a tested economic result.** The episodes were short and confounded by the Depression.
- **Time banking** (Cahn and Rowe, Time Dollars, 1992) shows that non-market, equal-credit exchange can run at community scale, with known problems of engagement and fair measurement. **Plausible** neighbor to the fixed morning gift.
- **Variable-ratio rewards drive compulsive responding.** CUD cites Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) for why the lottery was removed. That reasoning stands. **Supported** in its original sources as summarized in CUD; this companion did not re-verify those two citations and refers to CUD for them.

- **Commons governance.** Ostrom's Governing the Commons (1990) found that long-lived commons tend to share design principles such as clear boundaries, rules matched to local conditions, participation in rule-making, monitoring, graduated sanctions, and cheap ways to resolve conflict. Orun's hearings, rotated roles, and the painted list of taboos are close to that pattern. **Plausible** as a match in shape; Orun is not evidence for Ostrom, and Ostrom does not validate Orun.

1.3 Where it appears in the novel

Rule	Chapters
Fading glass; the dish "already smaller"	I, III, V, VII, XX
Floor at zero, no debt	Before; IV (Kesh's grandfather "writing debt on his shutters"); XI ("It can't fade past nothing. Nobody here can owe"); XIX ("Purses for the living are how lending starts"); XX
Fixed morning gift, no lottery	Before; I ("The amount does not change"); XVIII (the Day of Enough); XX (the closing scene at the dawn table)
Residual fading in luoma	III ("the residual leak"), XV, XVI
Thanks, not wages; help without obligation	XI (the thrown loaf; "Thank-you glass, not wages")
Rotation of roles	VII (the copy-table), XII, XIX

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2. Rivel: the knowledge of the dead, credited and consented

2.1 The rules [Design]

1. **Opening.** After a death, someone (kin, a student, a neighbor) pays an opening gift so the dead person's work can be copied into the commons.
2. **Credit in the dead person's name.** Every learning, use, teaching, or true mark that moves selu sends that credit to a purse in the dead person's name. The purse pays for more copies and more teaching. It is not a private fortune for the family and not a payment that undoes a grave.
3. **Value only while used.** Rivel that sits unused fades like idle glass. In the language of CUD, the purse's backing decays with idleness.
4. **Consent.** Keepers will not open rivel against a recorded wish for silence, or against a family's careful refusal when no wish was left. Private letters and methods a person asked to take with them are never sold. Kin may consent when no wish was left (Kesh for his grandfather, Chapter XIX).
5. **Reading is free; owning is not possible.** Anyone may read or learn rivel. A copy may be carried and used, but no one may sell rivel as their own property or lock it away (Bram, Chapters XI and XIX).

6. **True marks, not padding.** A mark has to add meaning, not a changed hem. Bundles of unmarked work cannot be relisted by tying them together. CUD's semantic-delta measure (`ΔH = 1 − cos(V_orig, V_mod)` on sentence embeddings) can serve only as a gate to human review, never as automatic approval, and a bundle must be compared against its most similar component.
7. **Living marks are named (new in the novel).** From Chapter XIX, a living person who truly marks a work has their name written beside the mark and said aloud once at the evening return. **No purse is created for the living.** This answers Tulen's question ("who's listening to us?") without reintroducing accumulation or lending.
8. **The dead do not answer.** Rivel is not a mouth. It does not bring anyone back, and using a dead person's voice to win an argument the living have not finished is a taboo (Chapters V, XII, XIX).

2.2 Evidence [Empirical]

- **Continuing bonds.** Grief research moved away from the idea that the healthy goal is to cut ties with the dead. Klass, Silverman, and Nickman's Continuing Bonds (1996) argued that ongoing inner relationships with the dead are common and can be healthy. Rivel is a civic form of a continuing bond: the bond continues through teaching and use, not through conversation. **Plausible** as a fit.
- **Oscillation in grief.** Stroebe and Schut's dual process model (1999) describes healthy coping as moving back and forth between loss-oriented work (attending to the loss) and restoration-oriented work (attending to life changes and new roles), with time away from grief as part of coping. Neru's arc is that oscillation: into the rivel and the voice, then out again to the living. **Supported** as a model with substantial research use; **plausible** as a description of Neru.
- **When grief becomes a disorder.** DSM-5-TR (American Psychiatric Association, 2022) added prolonged grief disorder: persistent, impairing yearning or preoccupation well beyond cultural norms. The novel does not diagnose Neru. The companion notes that if grief, looping, or preoccupation with the dead impairs life for a long time, that is a reason for care, not a reason to buy more rivel.

2.3 Where it appears in the novel

Rule	Chapters
Opening gift; credit in Alun's name	VI
Consent; the burned fever line	VI, IX (Vethan: "Did you put the fever line in?")
Copy-gift and the copy-table	VII
Value only while used	VI, VIII, X, XIX
Reading free, owning impossible	XI, XIX (Bram)

Rule	Chapters
True mark vs. a likeness	II (the voice-cloth Neru cannot certify), IX (Vethan's mark on the bend), XII and XIX (Tamar's line)
Kin consent for the fords	IV, VIII, XIV, XIX
Living marks named, no purse for the living	XIX, XX
Dead voice used to win an argument (taboo)	Before; XII; XIX

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3. The Ψ daily reflection index and believability scores

MindFrame, the earlier app in this research line, used a believability score `B` and a daily reflection index `Ψ` as weighted sums of self-ratings. Later notes in the collection already treat both as historical heuristics whose coefficients are not empirical effects.

The novel excludes them on purpose. Orun's customs say: "They never use a daily mood, or a believability of a harsh thought, as a score of worth" (Before). No character is scored anywhere in the story. The flow-state navigator and the game used state words, not numbers of worth.

Design rule carried forward [Design]. If any Orun-inspired app uses self-ratings, they stay private by default. They are used only for the person's own reflection. They are never ranked, compared, or tied to selu, the morning gift, or access to luoma. The CUD safety rule applies: monitors offer reflection and never punish.

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4. C-R-Z inside the story

Ryan Espinosa's C-R-Z framework has three pillars: **Calibration** (interrupt the inner loop with a brief cue), **Reality-Return** (re-engage with outside sensory input), and **Zero-Velocity** (put weight into the ground and stop the chase). Its action sequence is **Drop-Press-Snap**. The C-R-Z paper graded the parts: outward reorienting and slow breathing are supported, the plantar anchor is plausible, the foot "reflex point" and literal `v = 0` are speculative and were reframed.

The novel stages C-R-Z without naming it.

C-R-Z element	Dramatized as	Chapters
Calibration: notice and interrupt the loop	Neru recognizing "the same question already in her mouth, the same reply already sewn"	VIII, XIV, XV, XVI, XVIII
Reality-Return: outward listening	Listening for a key: the river, a sandal, a cup held out, gardeners, a call across water	I, II, III, VIII, IX, XV, XVIII
Zero-Velocity: weight into the ground	"She put her weight down into her feet on the cool floor, as if she were standing in the shallows feeling for the bottom"; "put her feet down hard on the wet stone"	XV, XVIII

C-R-Z element	Dramatized as	Chapters
The Drop (shoulders, weight)	“She let her shoulders fall”	XV
A living voice as a valid key (the C-R-Z paper’s correction)	Tulen’s question, Sareth’s song, Ilun’s sentence, Vethan’s call	II, III, VIII, XVI, XVIII
Sovereignty as the right to leave, not isolation	The west door; “Leave in good time”; Vethan’s leaving	III, XVI, XX

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5. The Drop: drop everything, listen for a key, exit the gate

5.1 The protocol as the novel teaches it [Design]

1. **Recognize the loop.** Signs: the same question already in the mouth; the same reply already “sewn”; a heap of pages you do not need; a doorway the body keeps turning toward; more input that changes nothing (Chapters VI, VIII).
2. **Drop everything.** Set down the purse, the maps, the rehearsed sentences. Do not fight the thought. Let the shoulders fall and the weight go into the feet (Chapters VIII, XV).
3. **Listen.** Not for the dead. For what is here.
4. **Do not take the first sound.** Wait for the key that belongs to now (Chapter XV, from Copilot’s draft).
5. **The key is present, never in the book.** A living person’s voice, a question, breath, the river.
6. **Exit the gate.** Walk out the west door toward the living; answer the living sentence (Chapters III, XV).

5.2 Failure modes the novel adds [Design], with their fixes

Failure	Where	Fix in the story
The surprise test fails. An imagined voice that never surprises you is your own voice in another’s cadence.	VII (Kesh: “When did she last surprise you?”), XII	Treat a never-surprising inner voice as a loop sign.
Silence becomes the loop. Listening alone lets the dead’s voice fill the quiet.	XVI	A living person speaks a direct truth: “I am the living person in this room.”
The Drop in public. You cannot drop everything in the middle of a hall.	XIV	Drop the sentence, not the room. Then check the facts.
The keeper’s lamp. A role becomes a hiding place among the dead.	XII, XV	Rotation; Tulen’s question taken to the whole hall (XIX).
A call with no answer. In a crisis, a key is offered and no one takes it.	XVIII	Answer the call: “Heard.”

5.3 Evidence [Empirical]

The C-R-Z paper (Sections 5.2–5.4) already graded the parts.

- **Supported:** thought suppression can rebound (Wegner 1994), so the Drop is letting go, not "stop!"; noticing that the mind has drifted is a real, trainable distinction (Schooler 2002; Smallwood and Schooler 2015).
- **Plausible:** defusion and "drop the rope" (Hayes, Strosahl, and Wilson 1999); if-then plans (Gollwitzer 1999); doorways as event boundaries (Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011), which fits "exit the gate."
- **Speculative:** the surprise test, which is new in the novel. Neither the C-R-Z paper nor this companion found a study of it. It is offered as a heuristic, not a finding.

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6. The calling: paired call-and-answer (new in the novel)

6.1 The rule [Design]

On the salt meadows, no one walks the water alone. Each walker calls what they see ("Knee at the stake"), and every call is answered ("Heard. Knee at the stake."). A call with no answer is the most frightening sound there is: it means someone has stopped. In Chapter XVIII the practice becomes Orun's, and in Chapter XIX it becomes a rule for high water.

6.2 Why it matters to the research [Empirical]

The calling is a social form of Reality-Return. It repairs the weak spot the C-R-Z paper found when C-R-Z is practiced as a closed, solo circuit.

- **Grounding in communication** (Clark and Brennan 1991): people in conversation work together to establish that what was said has been understood. They use acknowledgments, repetition, and read-backs. "Heard. Knee at the stake" is a read-back. **Supported** as a model of conversation; **plausible** as the reason the calling works.
- **Conversational repair** (Schegloff, Jefferson, and Sacks 1977) and **perceived responsiveness** (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004): **supported** neighbors.
- The claim that call-and-answer in a crisis improves coordination is close to standard closed-loop communication practice in high-stakes teams. This companion did not verify a specific study for that, so it is graded **plausible** and cited to no source.

6.3 Where it appears

Chapter XIII (introduced on the dike), XVII (Vethan explains it), XVIII (the rescue), XIX (adopted), XX (children playing at it; "Heard. Coming!").

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7. The flow states of Orun

The Flow States of Orun page maps twelve states and the paths between them. Its section on flow borrows Csikszentmihalyi's description of flow (Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience, 1990) as an absorbed state that can arise when skill and challenge are matched, and it does not claim that the twelve states are measured psychological states. **Grade: speculative** as a taxonomy, **plausible** as a self-orientation map.

State	Plain meaning	Main chapters
commons	Among the gift, the hall, everyday exchange	I, X, XI, XX
eshva	Empty, sinking, far from the room	III, XV, XVI
loop	The same knowledge or imagined talk circling	VI, VII, XII, XV, XVI, XVIII
listen	Dropped what was clutched; listening for what is here	VIII, XV
gate	A threshold that will not open for shouting	IV, XVII, XX
luoma	Rest, or rest used as a hold	III, XV, XVI
drawn	A living person or present thing reaching in	II, III, VIII, XVIII
outside	Staying beside a circle without entering	IX (Vethan), XVI (Kesh), XVIII (Ren and Sareth, not touching)
endure	Staying with a hard thing from inside	X, XX
rivel	Using the knowledge of the dead	VI, VIII, XIX
songs	Shared song and dance	VIII (the counting-song), XVIII, XX (the work song on the dike)
home	A return by choice	XVII, XVIII (Ren), XX

The three paths that leave the gate (being drawn out, staying outside, and enduring inside) are equal, as on the page. In the novel, Vethan's leaving in Chapter XX is a completed act, not a failed ending.

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8. Swapping thinking styles: a UDL framing, not “learning styles”

The flow-states page lets a reader choose one or two of six routes for the same twelve states: words and talking; pictures and imagery; movement and body; logic and steps; feeling and relationship; quiet or solitary reflection. None is the default, and every route leads to the same exits.

- **What it is [Design]:** multiple means of engagement, representation, and action. That is the framing of Universal Design for Learning (CAST, UDL Guidelines version 3.0, 2024): design for variability from the start, so that no learner has to be fixed to fit.
- **What it is not [Empirical]:** the “learning styles” claim that teaching matched to an assessed style improves learning. Pashler, McDaniel, Rohrer, and Bjork (2008) found evidence that people have preferences, but no adequate evidence for that matching claim. The routes are access options, not types of people, and not diagnoses.
- **The prejudice goal [Values, with an Empirical neighbor]:** Ryan’s aim was to equalize prejudice and support a diverse community. The nearest research is intergroup contact: a meta-analysis of 515 studies found that contact between groups typically reduces prejudice (Pettigrew and Tropp 2006). **Supported** for contact in general; **speculative** that swappable thinking styles reduce prejudice. That would need its own test.
- **In the novel:** the characters reach the same exit by different routes. Ilun gets there through quiet, then a single direct sentence. Kesh gets there through logic and a remembered saying. Vethan gets there through movement and calling. Sareth gets there through song. Tamar gets there through her hands, and Tulen through questions. No route is ranked (Chapters XV, XVI, XVIII, XIX).

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9. The attention budget: attention as selu

9.1 The model [Design / Values]

From C-R-Z Section 5.5: attention is a limited coin. Living people have priority. Absorption in an inner or fictional world is allowed on purpose, with a span and an exit cue. Attention spent on the living returns you to the commons. “Attention is life” is Ryan’s sentence; it is a values claim and a design rule, not a measured quantity.

9.2 What the novel adds

- **Attention to the dead vs. the living** (Chapters XII, XIX). If the whole town’s attention goes to the rack, who is listening to the living? The fix is to say living names aloud, plus one evening a month for the living.
- **Attention as the copy-gift that cannot buy presence** (VII). Neru spends real glass every night and gets only her own voice back.

- **Priority under pressure** (XVIII). In a crisis the living call outranks the beloved inner voice.

9.3 Evidence [Empirical]

As graded in C-R-Z Section 5: task-switching costs are **supported** (Monsell 2003; Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans 2001). The association between mind-wandering and lower momentary happiness is **supported** as an experience-sampling result (Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010). Intentional and unintentional mind-wandering differ (Seli, Risko, and Smilek 2016), which is **supported**. The selu budget as economics or neuroscience is **speculative**.

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10. The Connection Postulate in the novel (summary)

The full analysis is in the companion Analysis of the Novel. In brief:

Sub-postulate	Most direct scene
P1. Purpose cycles until connection completes it	Neru's rivel errand loops until she answers Vethan's call (XVIII)
P2. Fantasy both connects and traps	The voice-cloth (II); Kesh's night table (VII)
P3. The way out is honoring people outside the mind	Ilun's "I am the living person in this room" (XVI)
P4. Keep checking reality against shame, guilt, and false gossip	The gossip about Kesh (XIV)
P5. Connection takes priority, with bounds	"Heard!" (XVIII); Kesh's "Don't rush me" respected (IV, X, XIV, XIX)
P6. When memories fade, love remains	Neru on the terrace, losing the exact voice and keeping the felt love (XX)
P7. Being present to respond beats seeking more knowledge	Neru wanting "nothing from the dead at all" and answering Tulen (XX)

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11. Ethics invariants (all are kept)

Invariant	How the novel keeps it
Labeled fiction	Front matter and afterword
No lottery; fixed morning gift	Before, I, XVIII, XX
Selu fades, never below zero, no debt	Before, XI, XIX, XX
Rivel credited in the dead person's name, with consent	VI, XIV, XIX
The dead never rise	Throughout; the voice never becomes an outside presence; Ilun's "She is dead" (XVI)
Home only by choice (and leaving too)	IX, XIII, XVII, XVIII (Ren), XX (Vethan)
988 notice	Front matter and afterword

Invariant	How the novel keeps it
Dedication and credit	Front matter and afterword
Copilot acknowledged	Front matter and afterword

12. Master mapping table

Element	Layer	Chapters
Demurrage	Design	I, III, VII, XX
Floor at zero / no debt	Design	Before, IV, XI, XIX, XX
Fixed morning gift	Design	Before, I, XVIII, XX
Residual fading in luoma	Design	III, XV
Rotation of lamp roles	Design	VII, XII, XIX
Opening gift; credit in the name	Design	VI
Consent	Design / Values	VI, IX, XIX
True mark / ΔH gate	Design	II, IX, XII, XIX
Living names, no living purse	Design	XIX, XX
No score of worth (Ψ excluded)	Design / Values	Before
Calibration	Empirical (graded)	VIII, XIV, XV, XVIII
Reality-Return	Empirical (graded)	I–III, VIII, IX, XV, XVIII
Zero-Velocity	Empirical (graded)	XV, XVIII
The Drop	Design / Empirical	VI, VIII, XV, XVIII
Surprise test	Design (untested)	VII, XII
Silence as loop	Design	XVI
Calling (read-back)	Design / Empirical	XIII, XVII–XX
Flow states	Design (speculative taxonomy)	Section 7
Thinking-style routes (UDL)	Design / Empirical	XV, XVI, XVIII, XIX
Attention budget	Design / Values	VII, XII, XVIII, XIX
P1–P7	Values / Empirical (graded)	Section 10
Faith anchor	Values	Dedication

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14. Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) are cited only through Coherence Under Decay, whose reference list says its entries were cited from memory. They were not re-verified here.

Related works in this collection: Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, The C-R-Z Framework (13 November 2026); Coherence Under Decay (12 November 2026); Dynamic Boundary Control and Vacuum-Referenced Stabilization of Qubits (12 November 2026); the Orun pages The Path of Rivel, Voices of Orun, and Flow States of Orun.

AI assistance: Grok Bot drafted this companion under the author's direction. Microsoft Copilot contributed draft scenes and co-author notes to the novel, not to this companion's research claims.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.